DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Finite from Infinite: How the Book Ends

Daat Tevunot §189-195

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §189-195 (end of section 10, part 4, and part 5: the end of the book) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Monday 4 December 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Tonight we finish the book

The Rabbi opened by announcing that tonight they would finish Daat Tevunot. We are on page 632, towards the end of part 4 of section 10. He had run through the preceding material quickly a couple of weeks before, so he began with a review by questions.

- **What is prophecy?** A communication about God's attributes and His actions.
- **What happens to the prophet?** He loses consciousness and all his physical senses, which is why he falls to the floor as if asleep. Then he has to interpret the allegories he is shown. The Rabbi stressed that prophets were not only men: the Gemara counts at least seven women prophets, and says the women who left Egypt also had prophecy.
- **Where can a prophet err?** Not in prophecies about God's attributes, but in prophecies about His actions there may be room for doubt, and the prophet may need further guidance.
- **"You saw no image"?** They did not see God, only His manifestation in something, as in a mirror. Moshe's reflection was clear and single; other prophets saw unclear reflections, through how many mirrors we do not know.
- **Why images at all?** On a simple level, because that is the only way we can relate to Hashem. More deeply, because these physical images also teach about the physical world, which is what we finish now.

The meaning of prophetic images

On page 632 the Ramhal gives what the Rabbi called "a beginner's guide" to basic prophetic images, each matched to what God wants to show:

- **General providence over all existence**, with nothing missing: a light that circles the whole world like a firmament. "I saw something like a round firmament of light."
- **Justice and consequences**: a king sitting on a throne, with justice on the left and charity on the right. Everyone will face the consequences of their deeds.
- **The detailed way God sustains the universe**, His specific involvement in each thing: many cycles, one inside another, with the world in the middle.

- **The chain of emanations**, one after the other, down to this world: steps, with the world at the bottom. Part 5 will return to this.
- **Nearness and distance**: those who are better are closer to Him, those less good further away. The image is like a room within a room, or one garment over another, with the world as the outermost.

These are very general, said the Rabbi. Prophets were shown far more detail. But these are examples of how God shows things He cannot show directly.

Many images at once

The next paragraph says that a prophet on a high level may be shown all of these at once, though they contradict each other: one image is completely general, another is about detailed scrutiny of how you behave. The Rabbi compared it again to verses that seem to contradict but go together: the prohibition of a brother's wife and the misvah of yibbum, or "Zakhor" and "Shamor", said "in one utterance".

What is above nature is not governed by the laws of nature. We live within those laws, so for us it is contradictory. The prophet can understand it.

The Ramhal brings an example from dreams, "one sixtieth of prophecy". In a dream you see things that could never happen while awake, and they do not bother you. You see someone who looks like one person, and the next moment he is someone else. Prophecy, which is above nature, likewise contains things together that are unnatural for us.

In §191 the Neshamah says: you have made this very clear to me.

False prophets

A participant recalled from the Rabbi's podcast that a dream can come from a good angel, a bad one, or something in between. Is prophecy the same? No, said the Rabbi. Unlike a dream, where you do not know where the information comes from, prophecy by definition is information when you know you are communicating with the Divine. It cannot be good or bad, only clear or unclear, depending on the prophet's level. "You cannot be a prophet if you have doubt."

Then what of the false prophets in the books of Nevi'im, who had true information but were not good people? Apart from the category in the Torah of one who changes the Torah and is put to death, there were those who received information from the sitra ahra, the side of evil. They behaved like prophets, went through the same states, and gave true information about the future, so people followed them. But they were not communicating with the Divine, and they knew it. Some, the Rabbi added, had experienced real prophecy but took the easy, forbidden route when they did not want to do the work.

The Rambam sees it differently. In his laws of prophecy he says that if a prophet foretells something good and it does not happen, he is false; if he foretells something bad and it does not happen, it may be that teshuvah changed it. But for the Rambam there are no supernatural forces outside of God at all, so a false prophet is simply faking it and gets lucky, as some charlatans do today. For the Rambam, all the Torah's prohibitions of witchcraft and sorcery are prohibitions of nonsense. The Ramban, the Ramhal and most others hold that

these forces are real: "It works, but don't do it." The Rabbi mentioned the witch of Endor, which forces the Rambam's approach to explain the story away, while for those who accept such forces it is straightforward.

Why no prophecy today?

The Gemara says that after the destruction of the Temple there is no prophecy; anyone who claims it is impossible. Why, if prophecy is a state one works towards? A participant suggested one needs the vessel of the Mikdash. True, said the Rabbi. The Rambam says something simpler: without the Beit HaMikdash we cannot have true simhah, and joy is a fundamental condition of prophecy.

He brought a story that Tosafot on Sukkah cite from the Yerushalmi: at the Simhat Beit HaShoevah a simple man had so much joy that he received prophecy at that moment. That is why the prophets in Nevi'im prophesied to music, why David played the harp, and why music was an essential part of "prophecy school".

He also shared, tentatively, something he had come across and at first laughed at. Among the spices listed in Parashat Ki Tisa is kneh bosem, and some academics argue that the word "cannabis" derives from it; he read out such a claim. "We hear the word drugs and it's automatically negative." Perhaps such substances, in moderation, were part of the process. "I don't know, we don't have evidence."

Part 5: §191-193, the final question

The Rabbi warned that this last chapter is "not very satisfying": it does not really answer its own question.

The Neshamah asks one final thing, not about prophecy and not so relevant, but it would still like to know: how can finite material existence come from an infinite God? Can we understand that?

§194: what cannot be known, and what can

The Sekhel answers. As I have told you many times, how God Himself acts cannot be understood. We can understand only the results of His actions and the way they come about. This finite matter is something completely new, made in His great wisdom, which we cannot understand.

"That's the answer, by the way," said the Rabbi. How God makes the finite from the infinite we cannot know, because that is asking about God's own action. But the process, how it relates to us, we can understand, and the Ramhal now explains it.

He wondered aloud why this chapter did not come at the beginning of the book, since the whole book is built on the emanations it now explains.

Was the world "in potential" in God?

The Ramhal says the finite world was always in God's will; nothing new arises in God. The Rabbi pressed the group. The universe may be some fifteen billion years old, "the current scientific

consensus, fine", but God existed "before" that. Was it always His will that a universe would come into being? Yes, because God never changes. So was the universe "in potential" in God?

A participant compared it to an architect's blueprint, drawn long before the house is built. That is the intuition, said the Rabbi. But the Ramhal rejects it: "do not call this potential in Him." Speaking of potential in God detracts from His simplicity; we cannot describe Him in the terms we use for the world. You can say a student has potential to win the race; you cannot say that of God.

Another participant made the key distinction: we were in potential, as the trees in Bereshit were in potential waiting for rain, but not in God. "Fine, good, you've understood it very well." Asked about the Midrash that the Torah preceded the world as its blueprint, the Rabbi agreed the Torah is a creation, not infinite. And imagining a state with no universe at all is beyond us; "don't go there."

Emanations: the chain to the physical world

What we can say is that when God willed to create the universe, He brought forth emanations, ordered from the highest down, and the purpose of each was to bring about what follows it. Only the last emanation is called the cause of the physical universe. From the moment the first emanation came forth, the universe was "in potential" within it, because the last is included in the first and made for it. But the first is a very remote cause; the second is nearer; and so on down. "We could be talking about thousands or millions of emanations." In the Kabbalah there are ten sefirot, each with its own subdivisions, multiplied again and again.

The Ramhal adds a distinction. Before an emanation produces anything, it is called a hashpaah, something sent forth. When it produces something, whether a lower emanation or something physical, that result is called its toladah, its consequence. The second emanation is the consequence of the first, not of God directly. But the sending forth of the first emanation is like God's other attributes, His knowledge, His remembrance, His mercy. We cannot analyse those as we analyse a person's cleverness or compassion. We understand them only from what they do.

So what is the answer to the student's question? The Rabbi asked the group. "There's no answer." I cannot tell you how the first emanation came out; that is like asking about God's knowledge. What I can tell you is the process: each emanation is very elevated, then lower and lower, until the last is the root of the physical world.

Simsum

This, said the Rabbi, is what the Kabbalah calls simsum, reduction. Each emanation reduces the energy further, because if the first emanation were to create the universe directly, the light would be too much and nothing could exist.

The Arizal speaks of God withdrawing Himself, creating an empty space, and channelling a light into it. The Rabbi confessed that he does not know what "God withdrawing Himself" can mean; he has asked many times and never received an answer. "Theologically it's impossible." The Ramhal always follows the Arizal, but he says one cannot speak of God Himself contracting. The Rabbi's own understanding is that the simsum is the first emanation, which is

already finite, and everything onwards from it. That first finite emanation is the "empty space" in which the emanations develop.

He compared it to the Ralbag, a great rationalist, even more than the Rambam, who answered the question of free will and God's foreknowledge by saying that God chose to remove His foreknowledge of human actions. You can say that of a person who looks away; how can you say it of God, who sustains the universe every moment?

A participant asked whether this "withdrawal" is the same as the hiding through which evil was created. No, said the Rabbi. There God is still giving, otherwise everything would die; He is reducing, not withdrawing completely. "We're not going to understand everything. There are mysteries in life."

Another participant offered an answer to the Rabbi's question about placement: had the Ramhal put this at the beginning, the reader might have doubted the rest of the book, which depends on emanations whose origin cannot be explained. "Interesting. Could be."

§195: the Neshamah's farewell

The Neshamah says: certainly. I am very, very happy with my portion, for I have received from you great and deep understanding, and you have settled me in complete faith in all that every Jew needs to understand. And may there be peace upon Israel.

Then: "Blessed is Hashem forever, amen and amen." The Ramhal records that he completed the book on Thursday, the eve of Rosh Hodesh Adar Sheni, in the year 5494 (1734). He closes with the verse "For the Jews there was light and gladness, joy and honour", and the marked letters add up to 494, the year he finished it. The group worked through the gematria together, with a few false starts, until it came out.

The final lines pray that God will rejoice in His works, and the Rabbi drew out the parallel: Hashem will be happy with us, we will be happy with Hashem, and we will rejoice in our King, seeing His Malkhut and His Yihud declared in the universe. "Hazak barukh."

What comes next

Next week is Hanukkah, so no shiur. On Monday 18 December the group would summarise the section and the whole book, take general questions and reflections, hold a siyum with food to celebrate, and discuss which book to learn next. "Thank you everyone for joining us on this fantastic journey."

Summary

- Prophetic images match what God wishes to show: a circle of light for general providence, a king on a throne for justice, nested cycles and steps for His detailed sustaining of the world and the chain of emanations.
- A prophet may see contradictory images at once, as in a dream, because what is above nature is not bound by its laws.
- Prophecy is by definition certain contact with the Divine; false prophets drew on other forces (or, for the Rambam, simply faked it), and true prophecy needs joy, which is why it ceased with the Temple.

- How the finite comes from the infinite cannot be known; we can only describe the chain of emanations, each reducing the light (simsum), down to the physical world.
- The book ends with the Neshamah "happy with its portion" and settled in complete faith, completed by the Ramhal in Adar 5494.

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/E3eCest4pSg · More shiurim: rabbikada.com